



KEY EVENTS

1500–1650

■ **1515** King François I of France wins the Battle of Marignano, with a charge by fully armoured horsemen with couched lance.

■ **c.1540** German cavalry, the Reiters, adopt the wheel-lock pistol as their main armament.

■ **1562** Cavalry use the “caracole” tactic at the Battle of Dreux, during the French Wars of Religion.

■ **1590** At the Battle of Ivry, Henry of Navarre triumphs using a cavalry charge with pistol and sword.

■ **c.1600** European armies introduce dragoons – horsemen who fought dismounted with carbines (shorter muskets).

■ **1610** Polish hussars defeat the Russians and Swedes at the battle of Klushino.

■ **1630** In the Thirty Years’ War, the Swedish combine cavalry with other arms.

■ **1640s** In the English Civil Wars, Oliver Cromwell’s Ironsides cavalry fights in a disciplined close formation.

– a manoeuvre in which the horseman turned his horse to one side and then the other, enabling him to discharge a pistol to the left and right. The pistoleers rode at the pikemen in a column and fired at close range, each rank firing a volley and then retreating to reload as another line took its turn.

By the start of the 17th century, European cavalry had largely abandoned the lance, and also the percussive weapons that had been essential against full armour, such as the war-hammer. A cavalryman’s armament consisted of a sword and a firearm, or sometimes several preloaded pistols. Companies of dragoons rode to the battlefield, but fought unmounted with firearms, like musketeers. Commanders were, however, unwilling to abandon the cavalry charge: it was seen as glamorous, and could still be decisive in battle.

In the hands of leaders such as King Gustavus Adolphus of Sweden, cavalry recovered its shock effect. Deployed on the flanks of infantry, horsemen would first charge the opposing cavalry. Then, after discharging their firearms, they would attack with swords drawn; breaking through the lines would allow them to overrun enemy cannon. Bodies of musketeers augmented the mounted firepower, combining to drive the opponent’s cavalry from the field, exposing enemy infantry to attack.

“God made them as stubble to our swords. We charged their regiments of foot with our horse, and routed all we charged”

OLIVER CROMWELL, WRITTEN AFTER THE BATTLE OF MARSTON MOOR, 1644



◀ CAVALRY CHARGE

The English Civil War battle at Marston Moor, in July 1644, was won by the Parliamentarians through the success of Oliver Cromwell’s cavalry, the Ironsides. Their charge scattered the Royalist horses, leaving their infantry open to attack.